

# Be There

**You're in**

**Voting closes 2h**

**No organiser. No maybe**

Turning “we should hang out” into a firm plan.

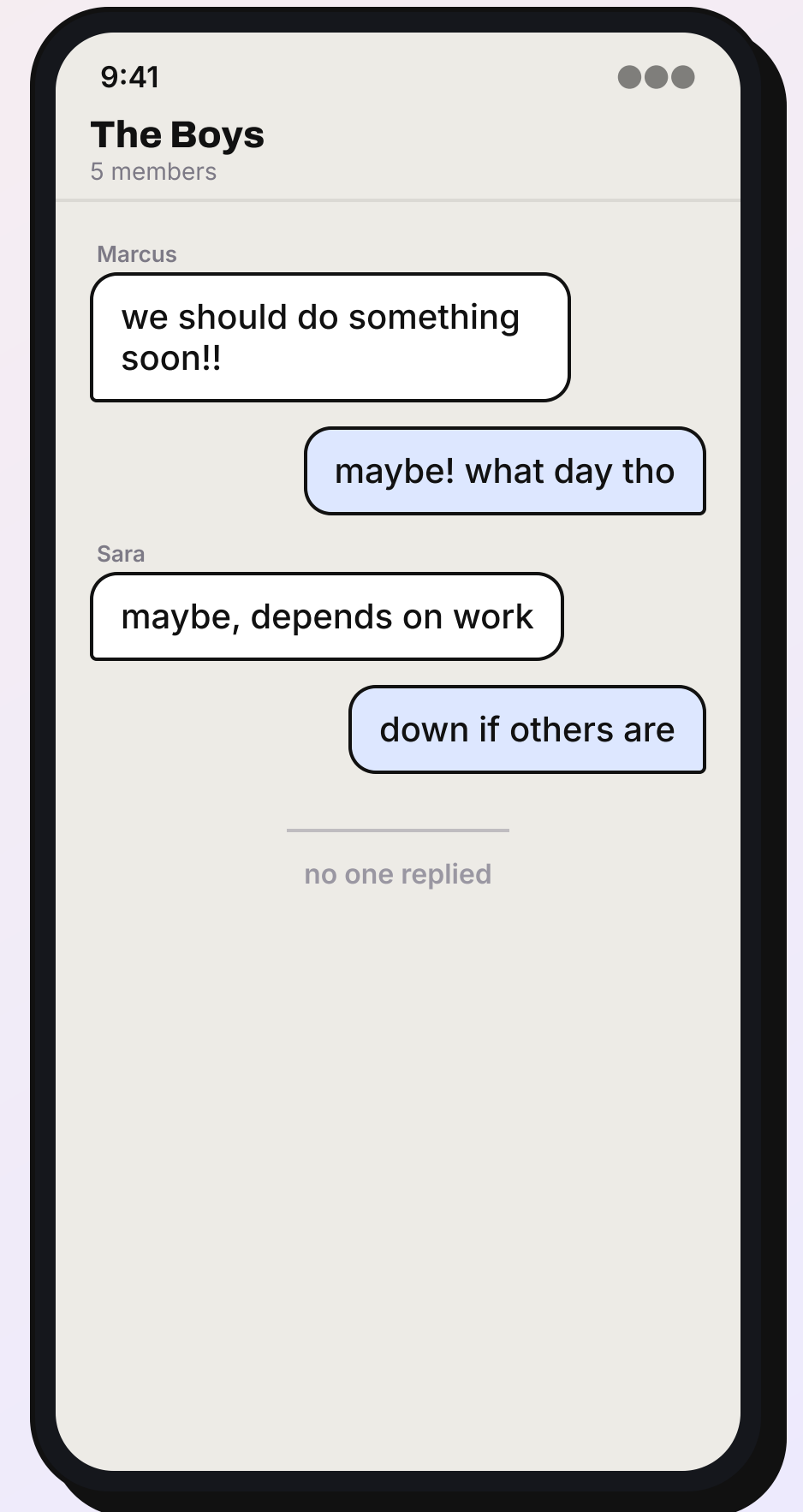
Nelson · Lukas · Noah · James

# It starts with a **spark**

Then a few maybes. One “what day though?”. Two people go quiet.

**Nobody said no. The plan just never happened.**

3 days later · still nothing



# The most connected generation - and the **loneliest**

A plan dying in a group chat is the everyday face of a much bigger shift.

**70%**

less time 15-24s spend with friends  
in person than two decades ago.

U.S. Surgeon General's Advisory on  
Loneliness, 2023 · American Time Use Survey

**40%**

of UK 16-24s feel lonely often or  
very often - the loneliest age group.

BBC Loneliness Experiment, 2018 · n = 55,000

**76%**

of young adults say seeing friends  
is how they look after their  
**wellbeing.**

ONS, Public Opinions & Social Trends, 2025

They want to see each other. The everyday cost of **making it happen** is the gap BeThere closes.

# It dies in the **silence**

The group chat gives you exactly two things - and both of them kill the plan.

01

## **A public “maybe”**

A socially safe way to hedge without ever committing. Everyone hedges, so no one is actually in.

02

## **Infinite time**

No deadline forces a decision, so the plan drifts. The longer it sits, the more doubts grow.

“ When someone expresses uncertainty, it cascades uncertainty on the group... that is a website written off.

- Luke, interview

# Plans dying is the **norm**

Friend Meetup Survey · n=43 · May 2026

86%

send a "maybe" or nothing at all when they are only slightly unsure.

23/43

say a third or more of their hangouts get talked about but never happen.

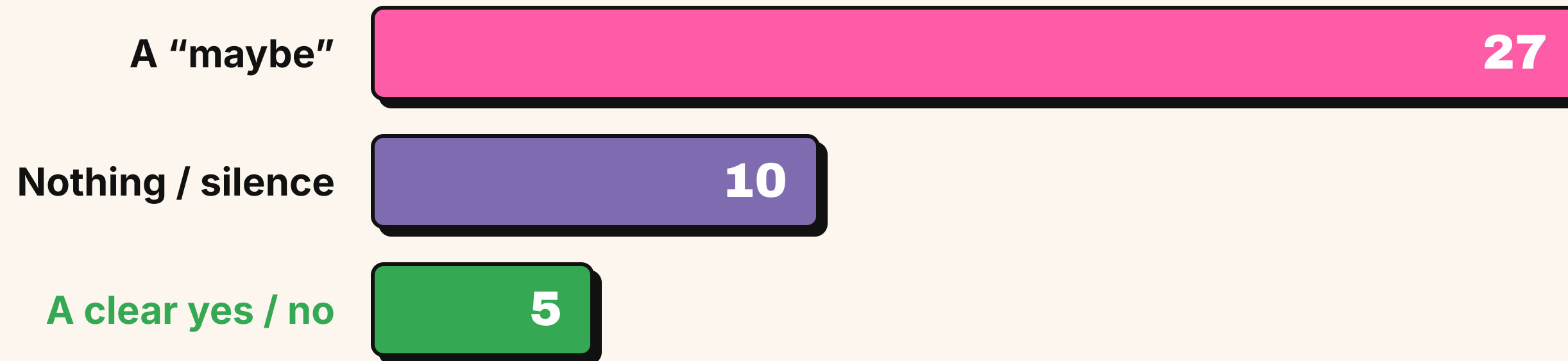
0

people said a **bigger** group made planning easier. 84% said smaller is easier.



# What people actually **send**

"When you are only slightly unsure you can make a plan, what do you send?" · n=43



Only **5 of 43** people give a straight answer. The "maybe" is the default - so what if the app didn't offer one?

# Straight from the **group chat**

3 rounds of interviews · the human reasons behind the numbers

“

Maybe means I keep the time  
semi-free - but if anything  
better comes up, I'll ditch it.

Matthew · the hedge

“

I'm normally the only one who  
actually wants to do it.

Luca · the asymmetric effort

“

I care less about what we do. I  
just want to see them.

Felicity · the real goal



**Hear it in their own voice**

Drop a 15-20s interview clip here - a real user on the “maybe”.

play live

# Meet **Millie**

Grounded in the real people we spoke to - Luca and Felicity · survey: only 4 of 43 say they lead



Drop a licensed stock photo - a  
~22yo student. NOT an AI-  
generated face.

CLICK OR DROP A PHOTO

**Millie, 22**

Second-year student

**Reluctant Initiator**

## **SHE WANTS**

To actually see her friends - without always being the one who drags everyone there.

## **SHE'S FRUSTRATED BY**

Being the only one who organises. Proposing feels like a risk - and the group assumes it won't happen.

## **SHE NEEDS FROM BETHERE**

To float an idea without it being **her** idea.



# She is not the **only** one

Four ways people dodge committing. BeThere's job: make everyone behave like the rare **Decisive One**.

**The Reluctant Initiator**

Wants it to happen, hates being the pusher.

**4**/43 lead

**The Hedger**

Keeps it "semi-free", ditches for something better.

**27**/43 maybe

**The Ghost**

Reads it, says nothing, waits for someone else.

**10**/43 silent

**The Decisive One**

Says yes or no cleanly. The minority we want.

**5**/43 clear

**DIRECT** Everyone who votes · friends named in a conditional · plus-ones & guests

**INDIRECT** The group chat we replace · venues · Clerk / AWS / Vercel

## THE PROBLEM

**Plans die in the gap between “we should meet up” and an actual time and place. Nobody wants to be the organiser, the effort is asymmetric, and a public **maybe** lets everyone hedge - so the plan quietly dies in a silent chat.**

OPPORTUNITY · HOW MIGHT WE

**Help a group of friends turn a loose intention to meet into a committed plan** - without anyone being the **organiser**, and without the social pressure of a public **“maybe”**.

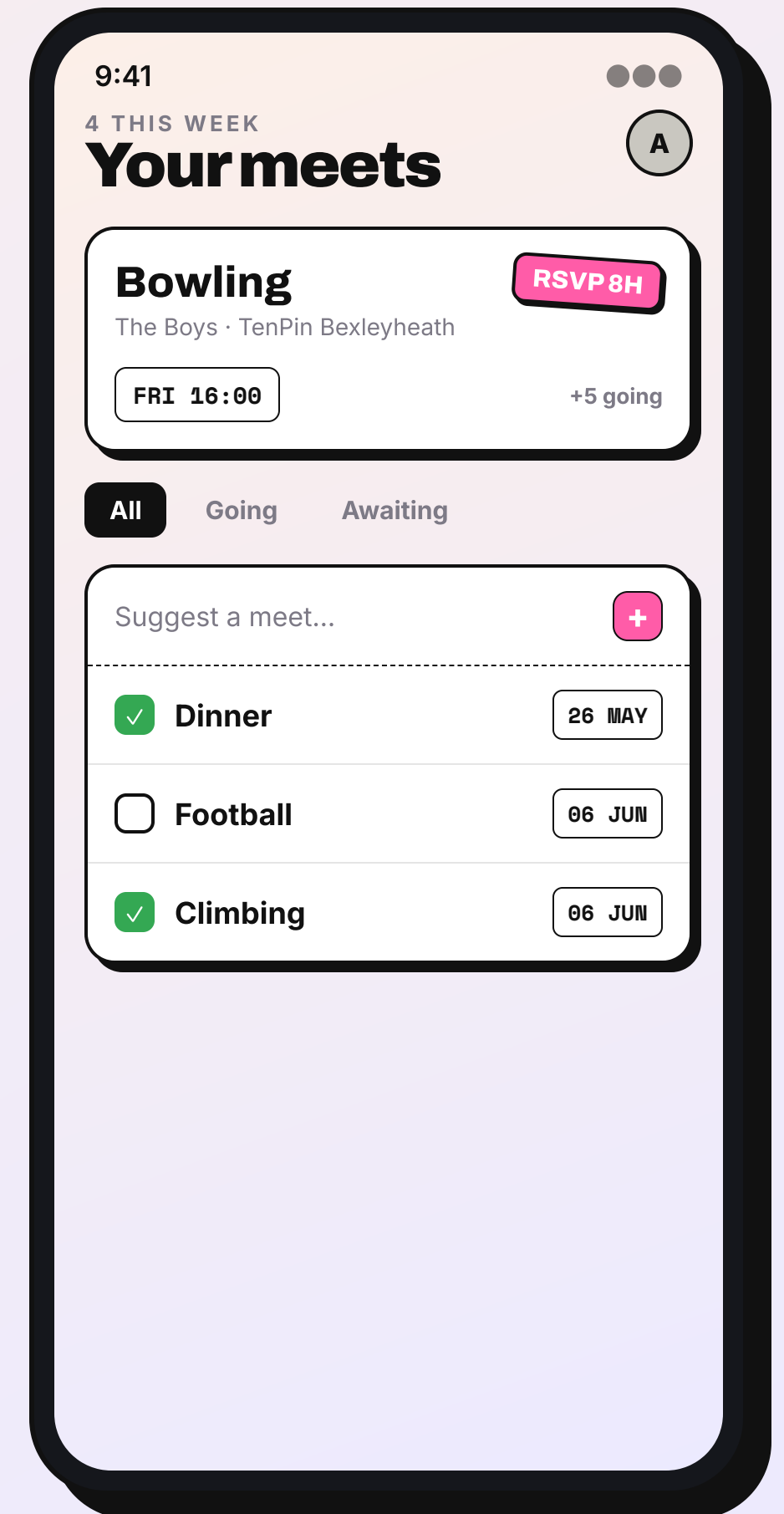
SO WE BUILT

# BeThere

**One person sends one plan. The group decides.**

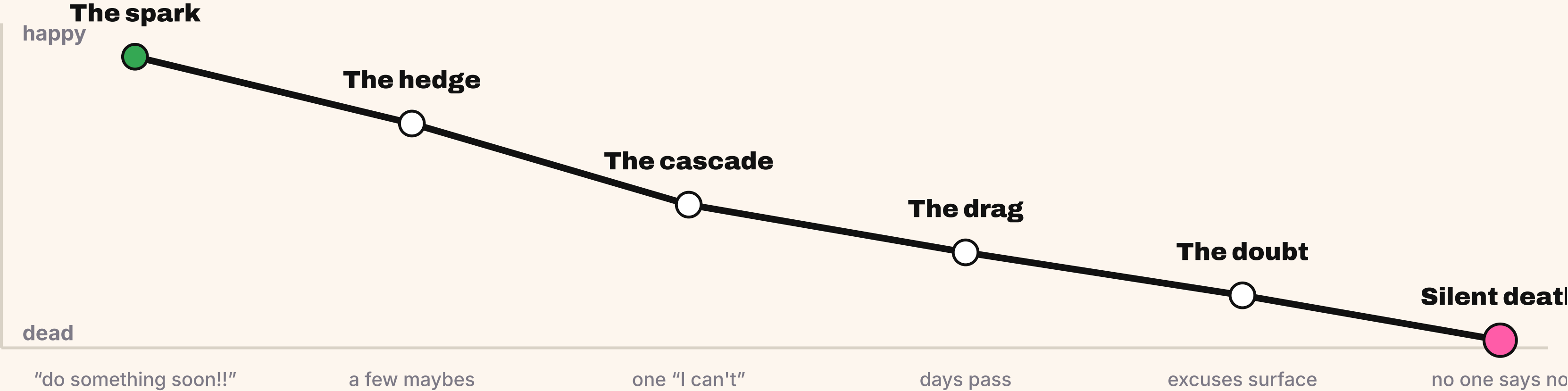
**No organiser, no maybe.**

The group sees the plan - never who proposed it.  
No names, just the group.



# Friday night, on WhatsApp

Current-state journey · emotion only goes down





# One person **sends** one meetup

Walkthrough · 1 / 4

9:41

<

Suggest a meet

●

Sent anonymously - no names, just the group

GROUP

The Boys

Reunion

TITLE

Bowling

WHEN - VOTE BETWEEN

Fri 16:00

candidate

Sat 14:00

candidate

Add a time...

+

Send to the group

**Candidate times, maybe an activity, a deadline. Sent anonymously.**

The group sees the plan - never who proposed it. There is no one to chase, and no one to blame.

INSIGHT

"Nobody likes being the one to push things... anonymity makes it a consensus." - Tom

# The group **votes** - no maybe

Walkthrough · 2 / 4

9:41

< Bowling · The Boys

Collecting votes  
Pick the times that work 2 DAYS

WHEN

|           |    |                                     |
|-----------|----|-------------------------------------|
| Fri 16:00 | +4 | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |
| Sat 14:00 | +1 | <input type="checkbox"/>            |

WHAT

|              |    |                                     |
|--------------|----|-------------------------------------|
| Bowling      | +5 | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |
| Dinner after | +2 | <input type="checkbox"/>            |

Counts are public. Names never are.

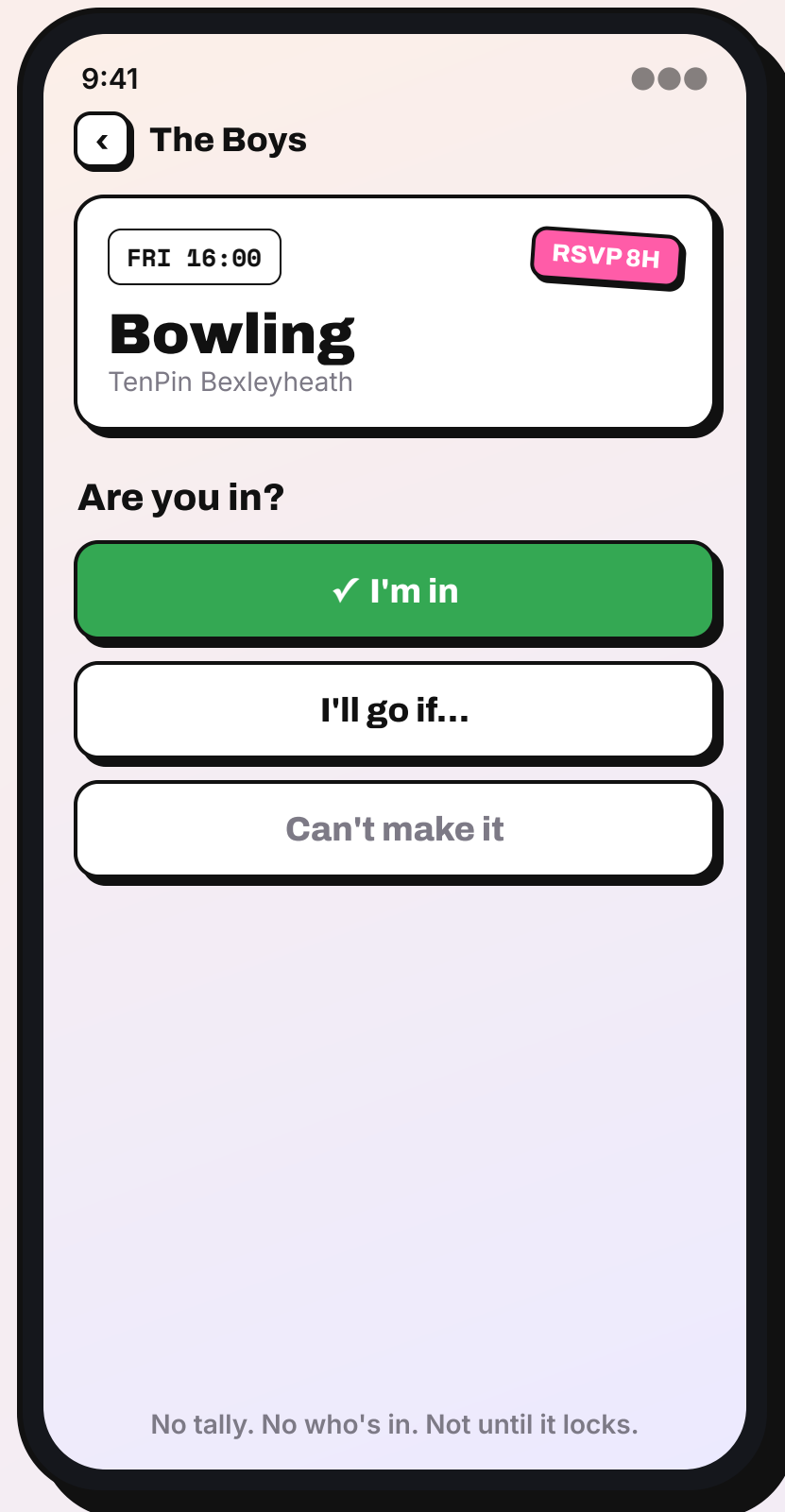
**Tap +1. See the momentum. Never see who voted.**

Counts are public, names are private. And there is no “maybe” button to hide behind - so one quiet member can’t cascade doubt onto everyone else.

**INSIGHT** 86% default to a “maybe” - so we removed the maybe.

# Then a blind **moment**

Walkthrough · 3 / 4



**The deadline auto-picks the winner.  
Then you reply **privately**.**

No live tally, no who-is-in. There is nothing to hedge against, so people just answer.

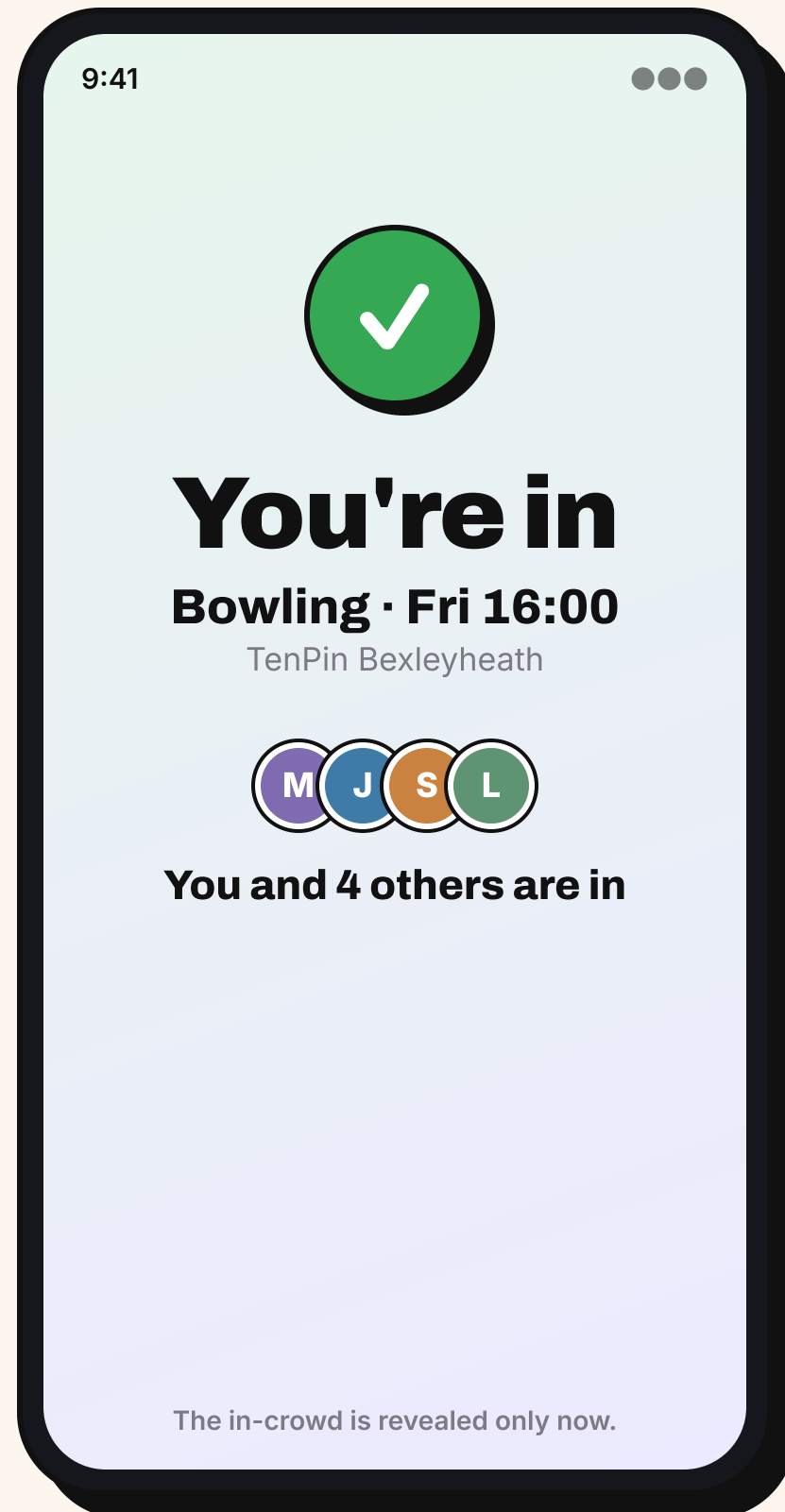
**“I'll go if...”** the conditional RSVP - defaults to “at least one” friend, never forces a name.

**INSIGHT** “A deadline with a push - like BeReal, it goes ding ding ding.” - Tom



# It clears, or it quietly **fizzles**

Walkthrough · 4 / 4



Enough commit? It **clears** - and the in-crowd is revealed only now.

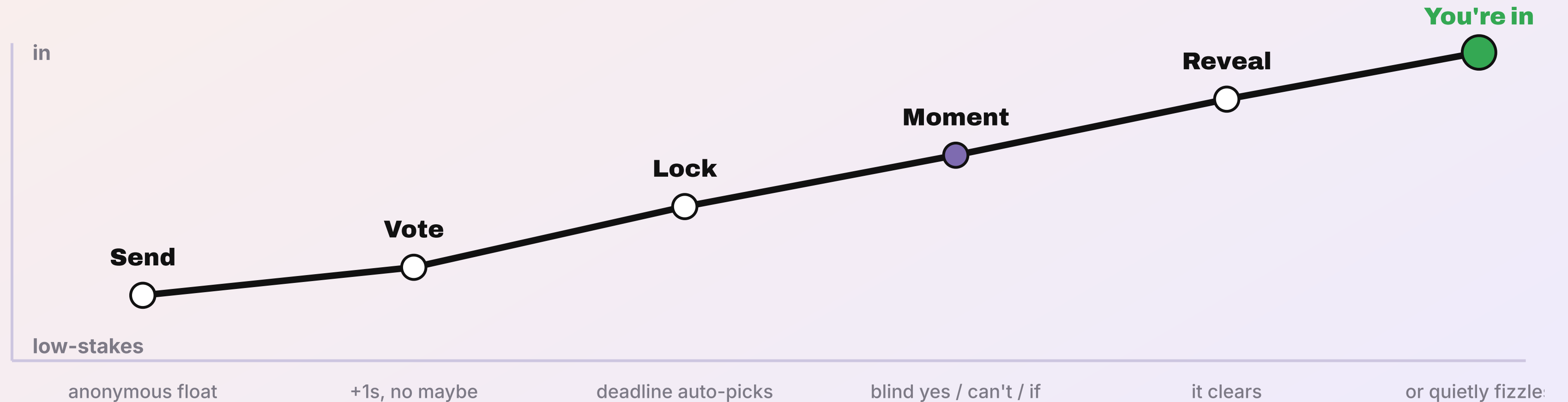
Commitment is shown only after it is safe to show it.

**...or it fizzles** no trace

If not enough commit, it disappears silently. Hidden from every dashboard. No failure notice, no dead thread - so no blame.

# And the curve **inverts**

Same Friday, same friends · momentum, never collapse



# Why **anonymous** changes everything

The asymmetric effort was never about logistics - it was about who carries the social cost.

SAID OUT LOUD

## **The cost lands on Millie**

"Millie's making us commit again." One person sticks their neck out - and the group reads it as her ask.



SENT ANONYMOUSLY

## **The group is converging**

The same plan becomes consensus, not a request. No one to push, no one to blame, no one to chase.



Nobody likes being the one to push things. Being anonymous makes it more of a consensus than one person giving a proposal.

- Tom, interview

# How the moment stays **blind**

Privacy is a property of the server, not the screen. Three guarantees, enforced in the backend.

## Anonymous creator

The creator's id never leaves the server. The client only gets a private "is this me?" boolean.

```
isCreator: boolean
```

## No live tally

Counts are returned while collecting, never the voter set. During the moment, nothing about others.

```
respond() → { recorded }
```

## Silent fizzle

Under quorum, the plan flips to fizzled on the next read and drops out of every dashboard.

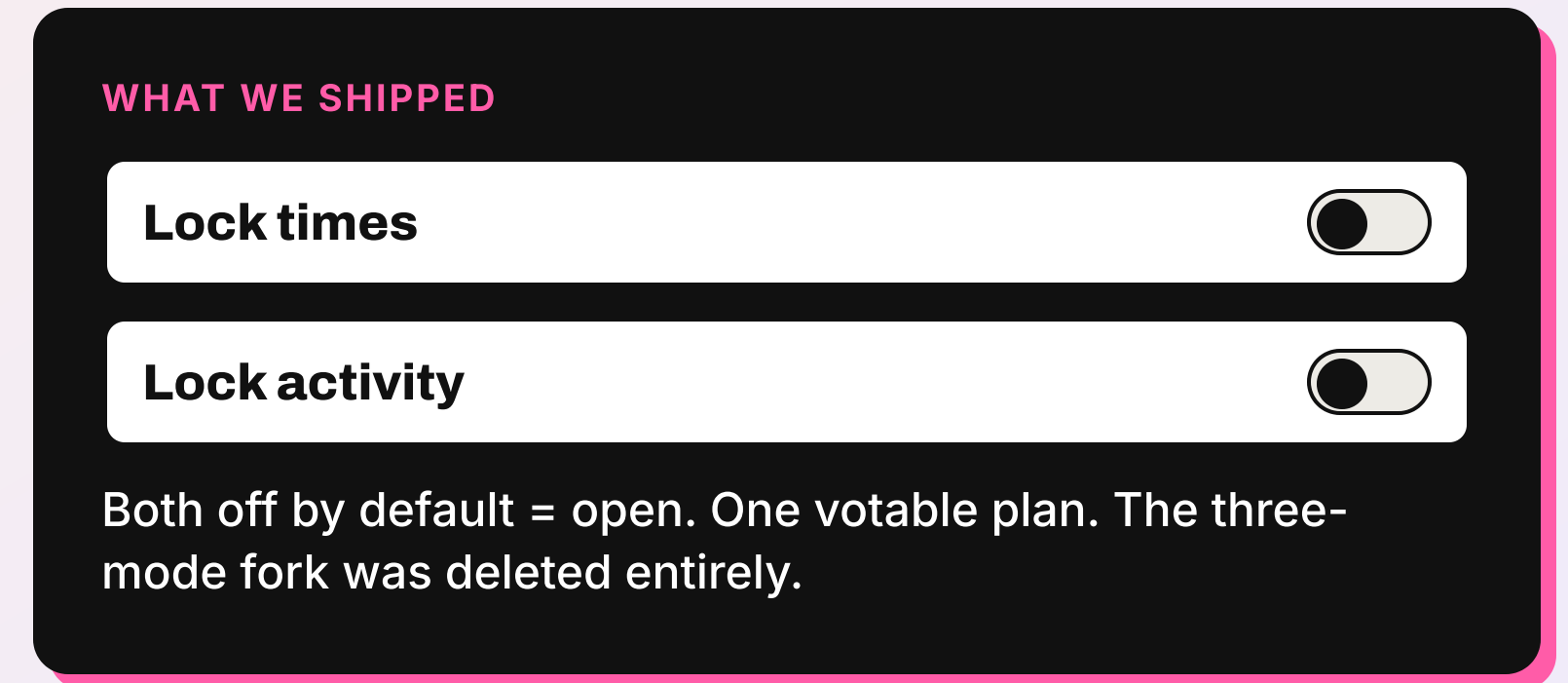
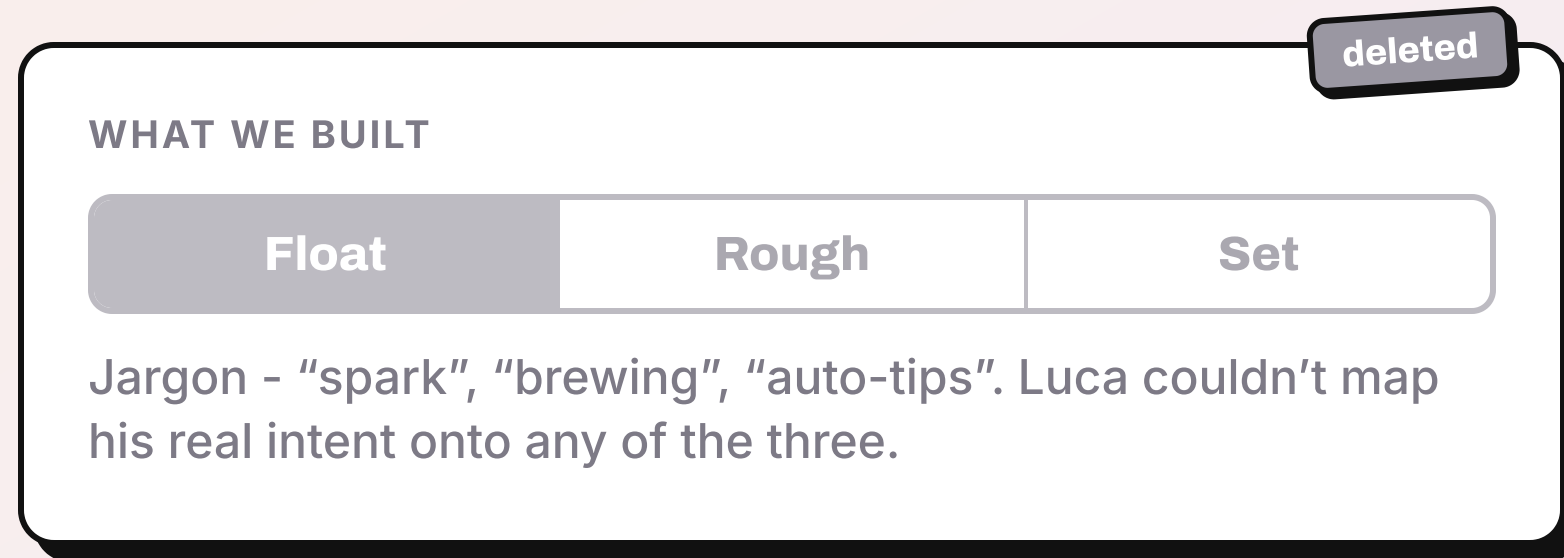
```
revealGoing()
```

## NO SCHEDULER

A plan settles its own phase lazily - the next time anyone reads it. The privacy boundary lives inside the server's procedures.

# Three modes became two **switches**

Our cleverest feature confused the first user who touched it. So we deleted it.

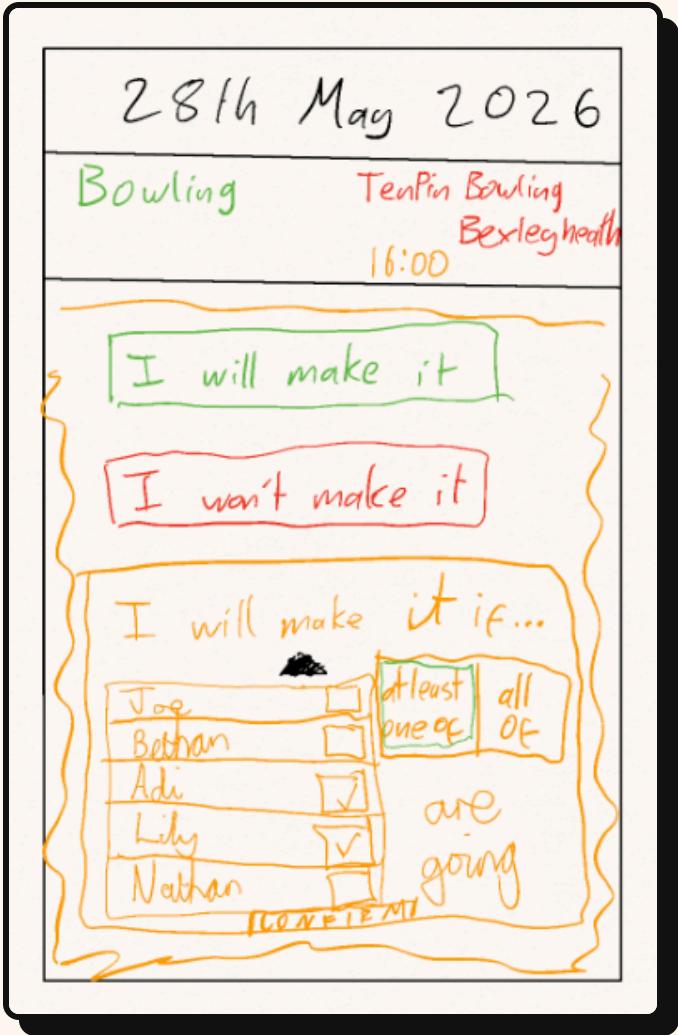


A real user simplified our information model. **DRP-41**



# The finding that pushed back

One participant rejected our favourite mechanic. We changed it - we didn't hide it.



Paper sketch • M2

## THE PUSHBACK

“I would feel so awkward actually writing down which of my friends I wanted to see.”

- Felicity, usability test

## WHAT CHANGED

“I'll go if” now defaults to **at least one** friend and never forces a name. **DRP-47**

# The download was the real **barrier**

A great flow is useless if Millie can't get her friends onto it.

replaced

WHAT WE HAD

**Add from a list of everyone**

Add member ▾

Aaron K.

Abigail T.

... 4,201 more, no order

Doesn't scale, no privacy, and it force-joins you to the group.



WHAT WE SHIPPED

**A link and a join code**

THE BOYS · JOIN CODE

**BOWL - 42**

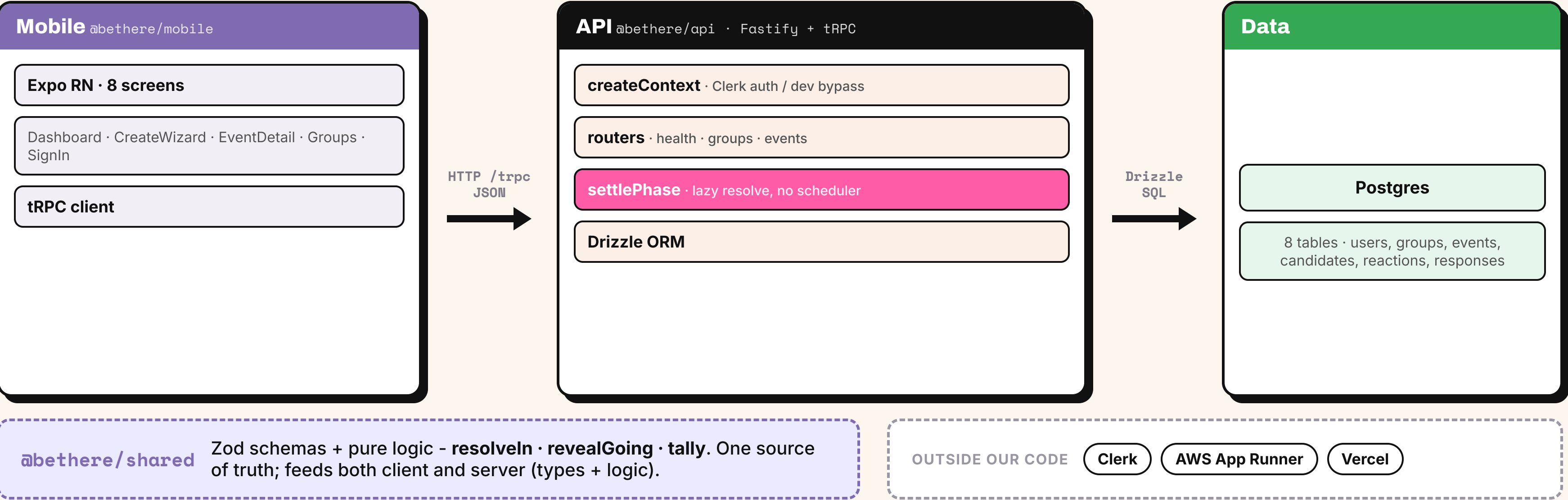
Share invite link

No download - the link opens straight in the browser, then drops you into the group.

**“It’s just a link - that feels much more seamless.”** - Luca DRP-50 · DRP-56

# Under the hood

— data & requests    - - - - shared types & logic





# Why this **stack**

Chosen for capability, not familiarity - every choice earns its place.

## tRPC + Zod

[@bethere/shared](#)

One schema is the single source of truth. A change that breaks the client fails at **compile time**, not in front of a user. (vs **REST + hand-written types**, which drift apart.)

## Expo / RN

[iOS](#) · [Android](#) · [web](#)

One codebase ships to all three. The web target is exactly what made the **no-download onboarding** possible. (vs **native iOS/Android** - double the code, no web.)

## Postgres + Drizzle

[typed SQL](#)

The privacy guarantees - no names, blind tally - live **inside the queries**, server-authoritative and out of reach of the client. (vs **Firestore** - less control over the privacy logic.)

## Lazy resolve

[no scheduler](#)

Phases settle on read - **no background job** to drift out of sync, and the privacy boundary stays in one place. (vs **a cron scheduler** - more to break, same result.)

# Built for the **group**

A plan only resolves if the whole group acts - so the interactions are between people, and they feel immediate.

## USER TO USER

**Anonymous voting** - the group +1s times and activities together

**The blind moment** - everyone commits in the same window

**"I'll go if"** - your answer depends on other people's

**Plus-ones** - bring a guest into one meetup, across groups

**Shared editing** - any member can fix a live plan

## RESPONSIVE

**Instant +1** - optimistic UI; momentum moves as you tap

**Conflict-safe edits** - compare-and-set; a stale edit reports a conflict, never clobbers

**Settles on read** - no waiting on a background job

**Honest gap:** real-time push is next - today the nudge is device-local.

# What went **well**

01

## **HCD reshaped the product**

We deleted our cleverest feature, made anonymity the spine, and kept a real tension honest. It got smaller and sharper because we listened.

02

## **It works, everywhere**

A deployed build on iOS, Android and the web - real friends used it on their own phones, not a mock-up.

03

## **We met the core need**

The two things that kill plans - the public maybe and the lone organiser - are both gone.

# What **changed** for them

We set out to make the whole group behave like the rare Decisive One.

## **The Reluctant Initiator**

Floats a plan without it being her ask - no one to chase, no one to blame.

## **The Hedger**

No maybe to hide in; a deadline closes it before second thoughts grow.

## **The Ghost**

A quiet +1 is now a safe signal - silence stops killing plans.

## **The Decisive One**

A blind, deadlined moment that finally makes everyone else answer too.

**The bounded claim:** we don't cure loneliness. We remove one specific friction that keeps friends apart - and 76% of young adults say seeing friends is how they protect their wellbeing.

# Honest about what's

## WHAT WE'D DO DIFFERENTLY

### Onboarding earlier

It only landed in M4, so our interviews tested the core loop, not the whole journey.

### Interview before we build

We slipped once. One of us insisted we validate it properly - now that's the rule.

## STILL UNMET · USER NEEDS

- 01** The felt-privacy gap in the conditional - test Felicity's "rank importance" alternative.
- 02** Reliable push notifications - the nudge is currently device-local only.
- 03** Beat the group chat people already live in - the web-first link is the first move.
- 04** We measured intent, not outcome - the study and telemetry are scoped, not yet run.

*We won't present an intended result as a measured one.*



# BeThere

You're in

Be there - without the **organiser**

“

**I care less about what we do. I just want to see them.**

- Felicity, the reason we built it

DRP · Group 02  
Nelson · Lukas · Noah · James